

“Everything else is public relations”

How rural journalists draw the boundary between journalism and public relations in rural communities

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Abstract: Rural journalists are news professionals, but also citizens engaged in their communities. The function and purpose of local journalism and public relations have become interdependent as media and communication has become more digital. These relationships create some tensions and it is in this environment that rural journalists make daily choices to cover a story or run prepared content provided by an outside source. Through the lens of boundary work, this study explores how (n=33) self-identifying rural journalists navigated this gray area and walked the line between creating authentic journalistic content and publishing public relations content. We found that in principle they identified stark boundaries between public relations and rural journalism based on journalistic norms, but in practice these journalists were often put in a position to engage in public relations work to support their communities.

Key words: public relations, journalism, rural communities, news deserts, boundary work

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As news deserts have grown (Abernathy, 2022) and the number of journalists in newsrooms has declined, the number of people working in public relations and strategic communication has increased (Guaglione, 2021). The number of newspaper newsroom employees across the country decreased 57% in the last 15 years (from 71,000 workers to 31,000 in 2020) (Walker, 2021). Employment for news analysts, reporters, and journalists is expected to decrease by 9% by 2030 (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2022a). By contrast, employment for public relations specialists is projected to grow by 8% (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2022b).

Therefore, the newsrooms in regions experiencing news poverty (Lindgren et al., 2016) are being filled with a plethora of press releases, media campaigns, and content that is often reprinted or posted to news organization web pages and social media accounts. In some cases, the editor will repackage the news content, but many times it runs as-is, either shortened with a “staff” byline or even republished word-for-word. While some journalists and journalism scholars see this as problematic – a compromise of objectivity and independence – the field of public relations has seen the depletion of original news content as an opportunity to generate content relevant to their communities. Journalists and PR practitioners both have a distinct *habitus* - internalized structures, schemes of perception, conception – but are also dependent upon each other (Costa & Murphy, 2015; Navarro, 2006).

Journalists and journalism scholars have had the privilege of defining journalism and public relations, however public relations scholars have elaborated their definition of PR beyond the field of journalism to focus on their service to clients and their client's publics (Van Leuven & Slater, 1991). This study seeks to understand the agency and utility of journalists who work in rural spaces, and how they conceptualize and navigate their relationships with public relations content and practitioners. While there is plenty of scholarship on how PR people and journalists work together (media relations), there is not a lot of information on what that looks like in small or rural communities.

Our study examines the practices of self-identifying journalists who cover rural communities and asks them to discuss how public relations is defined and contributes to their work. The roles of journalists in society have been defined by Christians et al. (2010) as monitorial, facilitative, radical, and collaborative, meaning journalists contribute to the overall societal understanding by doing their job in these capacities. Journalists primarily provide context and facilitate discourse around information of consequence such as education, politics, health, disaster, and economics. They often are dependent on public relations content to provide this information (Gandy, 1982; Weder et al., 2023). The Public Relations Society of America code of ethics defines PR as “a strategic communication process that builds mutually beneficial relationships between organizations and their publics” (PRSA, 2023). What is clear here is that both journalism and public relations seek to serve the public by providing information, but what is not as clear is how rural journalists amid increasing pressure to produce and fewer resources are navigating this landscape. Researchers analyzed data from long-form interviews (n=33) conducted in late 2020

and early 2021. The researchers sought to examine the following questions: What do journalists think about PR and PR practitioners (engagement), how do they use PR content (utility), and what does this look like in their work (technology and output).

Rural Journalists and Their Communities

Rural journalists take on the role of a brain trust of local information. Many of them identify as citizens of the communities they cover, and their journalistic roles, audiences served, economic realities, and citizen role orientations differ from their metropolitan counterparts. Rural journalists move around and in an orbit of a community. Their newspapers play a crucial role in community connection (Hansen & Hansen, 2011), and local news coverage and editorials play a role in community strength. Perhaps for self-serving reasons, newspapers at the local level can influence pro-growth community development (Molotch, 1976) because growth could mean more advertisers or new businesses could mean a bigger subscriber base. A local journalist, within the context of strategic community stakeholder, is a citizen and a journalist and therefore are part of the community or public (Perreault, 2021). Local journalists will be more likely to know their communities and understand the existing structures and politics of their communities (Scheufele et al., 2002) and build relationships because of strong ties to sources (Peters, 2011). These actions are more than transactional but rather involve complex decision making (Moon, 2019).

The size and homogeneity of a community influences reporting practices (Olien et al., 1968), and community structure (i.e. large versus small communities) can influence how journalists cover topics such as the environment (Griffin et al., 1995). And local media can inspire the community to act on important issues (Paranjape, 2007). Rural and urban journalists also serve

different audiences as the country's place-based political polarization increases (Parker et al., 2018). Studies show that hyperlocal news is still the most reliable source of news in rural communities (Carey, 2020), and local media provide important community connections (Hess, 2015). Although people trust the news less, local news is still more trusted than national news (Darr et al., 2021; Fioroni, 2022; Örnebring et al., 2020). Increased political polarization has resulted in an erosion of that trust. Recent research specifically on rural-urban ideology found that conservatives in rural areas show the greatest loss in trust in news media (Hmielowski et al., 2021).

Small and rural newspapers also struggle with limited resources. Some Midwest and Southern weekly newspapers function on a meager staff and struggle to recruit new writers and editors (Fargen Walsh & Martin, 2021). Many newspapers have seen their advertising revenues dwindle (Pew Research Center, 2021; Pickard, 2008) and readership decrease as they have been slow to adapt to digital platforms (Holcomb, 2018). Rural newsrooms are already situated precariously, as they sometimes lack the institutional infrastructure to train their staff in specialty reporting (Jenkins & Nielsen, 2020; Radcliffe & Ali, 2017; Wenzel, 2019). This can be problematic when covering issues that are more complex such as hate speech (Perreault et al., 2022b), health (Perreault & Perreault, 2021), and natural disasters (Perreault, 2021).

Understanding how rural journalists do their job is important because rural newspapers – many of them weeklies – make up a significant portion of local news, a reliable and trusted news source (Sands, 2019). A 2014 study (Coulson et al., 2014) on weekly newspapers found close to 70% of weekly newspapers were rural. And, local news is an important part of the communication infrastructure. A 2019 analysis of 663 local media outlets in more than 100 U.S. communities

found that more than 60% of content was original and filled critical information needs (CINs) in a community (Friedland et al., 2012; Napoli et al., 2018). That was more than local content on local TV, radio, and online news outlets (Mahone, 2022).

One reason small-market and rural publications have been able to sustain themselves in the face of economic hardship and political obstacles is support – both material and otherwise – from local communities. The focus of the present study is on a particular form of support: namely, content from public relations practitioners. No two rural communities are alike, but in the face of precarious working conditions and economic hardship, rural journalists may struggle to provide timely in-depth news without this support in the form of public information, press releases, and even community volunteers (Abernathy, 2018; O'Neill & O'Connor, 2008). The notion that journalists would heavily rely on content from strategic communications practitioners runs counter to the traditional journalistic value of independence or the measure of capacity to make decisions and act according to their own logic (Karppinen & Hallvard, 2016).

This long-held journalistic value distinguishes independent media from state media and, especially in the United States, has been a way to distinguish the agency and function of journalism from that of public relations. To further understand the complex role of journalists within these rural regions – as well as the complex relationship between rural journalism and public relations – we turn to existing scholarly literature on community journalism and, specifically, journalistic boosterism.

Journalistic Boosterism

As highlighted above, journalists in rural and small-market communities occupy a dual role as both community chroniclers and community members. While these journalists are trained to place themselves in an objective, non-biased position by virtue of their professional norms, they are also encouraged and expected to actively participate in the social fabrics of their communities (Metzler, 2021; Robinson, 2014). By reporting favorably on their region and its happenings, journalists engage in the ideological work of community-building (Kaniss, 1991).

Scholars have referred to this phenomenon as journalistic boosterism, or local news that serves as “both chronicler and cheerleader in urban society” (Burd, 1977, p. 129). This term draws on the concept of boosterism more generally, which refers to the way in which residents of nineteenth century American cities used print media to improve public perception of their communities, inspire local pride, and ultimately attract economic investment (Caves, 2005, p. 30). Similarly, according to Gutsche (2015), journalistic boosterism also carries economic imperatives. He explicitly defined modern journalistic boosterism as “everyday news that highlights the positive qualities of local environments, that profiles the successes of local personalities, and that promotes geography’s inherent promise for economic and social wealth” (Gutsche, 2015).

While journalistic boosterism is still in its “conceptual infancy” (Gutsche, 2015, p. 498), scholars have nonetheless applied it to study various forms of news. The concept is particularly prevalent in the literature on sports journalism (Anderson, 2000; Kim & Lowrey, 2018), in part due to a perceived bias in sports reporters’ coverage of home teams. As Hardin (2005), quoting a sports reporting textbook, noted, “how can a reporter objectively and accurately report on a team when the reporter is practically part of it?” (p. 67). Scholars have also examined journalistic

boosterism in relation to city magazines, which Burd (2008) described as “largely civic boosters rather than critical journalism” (p. 213). Confirming Burd’s contention, Jenkins (2016) found that these publications selectively covered certain topics over others in order to gain readership – particularly an elite, affluent audience – and, thus, appeal to advertisers. Scholars have also explored the concept of boosterism outside of a U.S. context (Leupold et al., 2018). In a study of reporters in Australia and Canada (Richards, 2013), for example, found that journalists wrestled with their journalistic commitment to building community, on the one hand, and not acting as an advocate, on the other. Richards’ findings indicate that “local journalists appear to feel an obligation to present news and information in ways which support [the best interests of the community] ... and which do not undermine local pride or cohesion” (p. 640). Recently, local journalism scholars have examined how small-town journalists take on the role of caretaker of their community (Mathews, 2021) and practice an ethic of care to understand their biases and how they might interact and affect their communities (Robinson, 2023). These rural journalists are working in newsrooms that are sometimes in financially precarious situations. The caretaker role also can create some ethical precarity when it comes to long-term career stability, success and relationships with sources.

Boosterism would seem to run counter to the normative expectation of journalism regarding objectivity, a norm employed to “convince receivers that they produce reliable and valid descriptions of reality” (Skovsgaard et al., 2013, p. 24); essential, given that objectivity may indeed be the “defining norm of modern journalism.” The norm has been criticized in large part as long as it has been employed (Vos, 2012) because it would seem to “relegate journalists to a subservient, spectator role in serving the public interest” (Stoker, 1995, p. 11). It is a myth that runs deep within

the profession as a part of the story of why journalists do what they do (Schudson, 2001); hence, why journalists can operate in tension between the needs of their community and the expectations of their profession (Metzler, 2021; Robinson, 2014). While much of the existing literature has focused on journalism in urban communities (Burd, 1977; Kaniss, 1991), we argue that journalistic boosterism is instructive in understanding the role of journalists in small-town and rural communities for a variety of reasons. For instance, journalists struggle to gather sources that are new and novel in smaller communities. They also cannot remove themselves from conversations in their communities because they are concerned about where they live and work (Gutsche & Hess, 2018; Gutsche, 2015; Jenkins, 2016). Many news organizations have used boosterism as a default, which sets local news organizations apart from national news outlets because of their proximity to their readers and sources (Kim & Lowrey, 2018; Metzler, 2021). Perhaps, then, boosterism is a strategic approach similar to the strategic management function of public relations. What does it mean to consider journalists might be dependent on – and sometimes performing – acts of public relations? To answer these questions, we turn to a theoretical framework drawing on the concept of boundary work (Carlson, 2015; Carlson & Lewis, 2019).

Boundary Work in PR and Journalism

Journalists have sought to create a distinction between journalism and public relations through professional organizations, academic training, and certifications. Journalists often use boundaries to distinguish their work from the work of citizens and other communicators. This is done through the practice of re-establishing journalistic norms and values (Belair-Gagnon & Holton, 2018; Carlson, 2015). While journalists and public relations practitioners both consider

their audiences to do their work effectively, some scholars have argued their boundaries are becoming increasingly less distinct and more like fraternal twins than cousins (Duffy et al., 2015). Indeed, journalism has been argued to have a “soft boundary” that naturally results in “more communication with adjacent fields (Perreault & Hanusch, 2022, p. 4). A soft boundary proves valuable in many fields in that, while it allows for influence and dependence on other fields, it allows a field to be adaptable to change (Benson, 1999, 2004). Strategic communication research has also found that citizens who speak in a community to be vital in crisis and disaster response (Cancel et al., 1997; Grunig, 1983), for political and social engagement (Rojas, 2008). Similarly, journalists and public relations practitioners often work closely together in times of crisis and disaster (Reynolds & Seeger, 2005), such as COVID-19 (Perreault et al., 2022a).

Journalism scholars have found four dominant practices that have been associated with journalism over time: 1) research, 2) freedom of speech, 3) a pursuit of truth and accuracy, and 4) integration of ethical principles (Pavlik, 2013). Public relations practitioners and advertisers seek to practice ethically but are often informed by personal experiences and individual orientations (Schauster & Neill, 2017). As the paradigm of news creation and distribution has shifted, so have the expectations of journalists and those of public relations practitioners (Macnamara, 2012; Schönhagen & Meißner, 2016; Waters et al., 2010). Public relations also acknowledges this shift (Sallot & Johnson, 2006; Sallot et al., 1998; Weder et al., 2023). This relationship involves journalists and public relations practitioners contributing to the public agenda and discourse (Sallot & Johnson, 2006).

Foundational work in PR by Grunig and Grunig (2008) defines good (or excellent) public relations practices as skilled communication, done in a way that is accountable to the client's public and representational of the client with effective communication. Another thread identifies successful or competent public relations (Tench & Moreno, 2015) as a mixture between communication skills, insider knowledge, motivation for engagement, tailored outcomes, and specific context (Hazleton, 2006). The relationship between public relations as an agenda setting function in communication found in the Press Agency Model (Cutlip, 2013) is one that is interdependent on the trust between the practitioner and new organization or journalist (Zoch & Molleda, 2006).

Journalists and public relations practitioners exist in a symbiotic relationship. Barnoy (2022) found that when journalists sought trusted information, a paradox between the epistemology of journalism and public relations existed, but at the same time journalists relied on PR even if it reduced the "vulnerability to factually incorrect messages" (p. 89). That said, the othering between journalism and public relations — journalists referring to PR as "the dark side of journalism" and PR practitioners seeing journalists as "biased and misleading" perhaps represent the daily complexities of this relationship and the challenges of defining the boundaries between interdependent professions (Macnamara, 2012; Sherwood et al., 2019). This representation of a boundary will result in collaborations between different communities of practice and could be the start of understanding their functions better (Star, 2010). However, journalists and public relations practitioners are often educated alongside each other, and increasingly local journalists have an obligation to practice responsible journalism even as they incorporate strategic communication

approaches in their reporting practices (Perreault, 2021). Journalists often leave their jobs to work in public relations for increased pay and more predictable schedules (Mathews et al., 2023). Public relations practitioners also understand their role—or *habitus*—as one that interacts with and is sometimes dependent on journalism (Edwards, 2006; Ihlen, 2005; Navarro, 2006).

As journalists relinquish more gatekeeping power (and in many ways become mediators of communication and collaboration) with more digital and online publication, journalists are not creating new information, but they are rather recirculating it and verifying (Holtzhausen, 2005; Knight & Sweetser, 2021). Journalists at the local level may focus on covering harder news stories on government, crime and education, but their stories might lack depth because of source diversity (O'Neill & O'Connor, 2008). According to Lehman-Wilzig and Seletzsky (2010, p. 38), “‘Hard’ news demands immediate reporting due to its importance and short lifespan (continuing stories tend to follow shortly).” . Most local news would fit into a general news category (Lehman-Wilzig & Seletzky, 2010; O'Neill & O'Connor, 2008).

Journalists often face challenges to diversify sources and work in ways that challenge traditional ideologies and practices (Wenzel, 2021). Reporting plays a role in communication in that it connects journalists, citizens, and information. Because this study was conducted during the first year of the COVID-19 pandemic, we find it vital to include some literature about the work of both journalists and public relations practitioners in crisis. It is understood that in a crisis, the amount of information increases, and journalists have a role in that exchange of content.

Journalism scholars have argued that a clear delineation of public relations practice and journalism practice might actually be an illusion in spaces where resources are sparse and networks

are limited. Journalistic ethical frameworks and values are sometimes built on unachievable ideals, which with shrinking newsrooms are even less possible. This leads us to the following research questions:

RQ1: How do rural journalists define the roles of rural journalists and public relations practitioners?

RQ2: How do rural journalists describe the role of public relations content in their organizations?

RQ3: What lines do rural journalists draw between public relations work and newswork?

Method

To address these research questions, the research team reached out to journalists who were covering rural areas. Participants were contacted through a purposive sampling procedure (Koerber & McMichael, 2008). For this study, each researcher contacted several journalists in U.S. states. Journalists were defined as those working primarily in the practice of journalism for their main job by writing and publishing on timely and pertinent news topics (Fröhlich et al., 2013). Journalists were included if they self-identified as working in or covering a rural area. The U.S. Census defines rural as areas that are not classified as urban (U.S. Census, n.d.). Pinning down a definition of rural is difficult. While some have argued that rurality is a social construct (Woods, 2011); others have argued that a journalist's association with place is vital for how journalists function in their work and communities (Usher, 2019). Therefore we allowed our journalists to self-identify as rural journalists.

In addition, the researchers identified the work of journalists in these areas as rural journalism based on the circulation of their news organizations, as well as the size of the community they covered (Perreault et al., 2022b; Smith, 2019). Journalists were recruited through established contacts and lists provided by professional organizations. Journalists were also sought through snowball sampling on social media sites Facebook and Twitter.

Each participant was interviewed individually (n=33) by a member of the research team. They worked for several news organizations including but not limited to the *Avery Journal-Times* (N.C.), *The Houma Courier* (La.), *The West Side Journal* (La.) and the *High Point Enterprise* (N.C.). Although some of the news organizations were not situated in rural areas, we included journalists who reported primarily on rural areas given that they would still be conducting rural journalism. Participants were recruited via email and interviewed via Zoom, which has proven to be particularly helpful for providing rich interview responses (Wahl-Jorgensen, 2021). This was done following approval from the researchers' Institutional Review Boards from November 2020 to March 2021 (Appalachian State University approval #20-0055).

Journalists who covered rural areas were interviewed (n=33) using a semi-structured questionnaire that covered a range of topics related to rural journalism. Prior to the interview, in accordance with our ethics approval, journalists were informed about the topics that they would be asked through an information sheet that reflected the bounds of the study; these topics included their working relationships with public relations professionals. The interviews resulted in a significant corpus of qualitative data, and for this study, we are analyzing data from two areas: (1) questions about journalist's perceptions and experiences with public relations, and (2) questions

about their experience in evaluating information from their sources (e.g. public relations professionals from civic organizations, governmental organizations). For the purpose of this study, we are evaluating a line of questioning related to their perceptions of public relations professionals and how rural journalists delineated the boundaries between the fields. Sample questions included: What does the term 'journalism' mean to you?; What skills differentiate public relations and journalism?; Tell me about your interactions with public relations people—what have those interactions been like?; and In what ways do you see your job crossing the lines between journalism and public relations? Of those whose demographic information was available (n=31), 15 identified as women and 16 as men. All but two journalists (n=29) were white. The respondents lived in Missouri, Ohio, Florida, Kansas, Iowa, Indiana, Illinois, Minnesota, Nebraska, North Carolina, Kentucky, Tennessee, and Louisiana. The average number of years of journalism experience was 17, with a median of 9 years of experience (for those who shared their demographics). Similarly, 20 (of those) respondents had journalism degrees. All respondents self-identified as rural journalists and described their work as rural journalism. De-identification was granted to all participants in part because we were only interested in generating themes regarding rural journalists' experiences with public relations.

Researchers transcribed the interviews and used textual analysis on the transcripts. Using a constant comparative approach (reading through and re-reading content) (Glaser & Strauss, 1967), the researchers met over a series of Zoom calls to reveal themes and narratives in relation to addressing the research questions.

Findings

Rural journalists clearly articulate their jobs as different in mission and practice than that of a public relations practitioner, but in reality they described the lines between principles and practice as being blurry. When asked about the differences between public relations work and journalism, participants drew stark lines between newswork and PR work. When it came to practice, many discussed the difficult balance of being a journalist in a rural community where they are expected to write positive stories that promote the community such as feel-good sports stories, features of new businesses, or rewritten press releases. Participants acknowledged public relations being a part of their job, although they had concerns about over-reliance on PR information and even engaged in intentional PR work themselves.

Drawing stark lines: Journalism versus public relations

In regard to RQ1, “how do rural journalists define the roles of journalists and public relations professionals,” rural journalists described adhering to ethics and journalistic norms such as the watchdog role, objectivity and fairness values when describing journalistic work they do in rural communities. Participants described ways they define their work and service to their communities.

Journalists often described their work in journalism and public relations as juxtaposed, in that they could commit *acts* of public relations in their journalism work in order to serve the community in a different way. For example, one journalist said they covered things just “public relations wise, like the schools doing something good or the Chamber of Commerce event” in order to gain a positive reputation for the news organization (Rural Journalist 3). These were acts that needed to be done as a way of “benefiting the general public” (Rural Journalist 1). By contrast,

Rural Journalist 3 also described their truth-seeking role. They described “trying to report on just the facts of the matter and always trying to get to the truth of it... . Journalists search for just the facts in mind” (Rural Journalist 3).

Rural Journalist 31 described similar skill sets needed for journalism and public relations, but that’s where similarities ended. They described journalism as a “commitment to the truth,” while public relations is “literally designed to please and to present spin on things.”

Several journalists mentioned seeking information from sources they could verify or were easy to confirm (public officials, education sources, administrators, assistants), also sources they had gotten to know and trust. Rural Journalists 3, 8, and 33 discussed the dynamics of living in a smaller community with limited sources or only a single source to consult about health, crime, or other community issues. Rural Journalist 8 discussed the importance of going to specific trusted “primary sources” when dealing with controversial topics – these were often government or other official sources.

Rural journalists described a view of public relations that included a mission very different from journalism. Participants described public relations professionals as doing work that served a company or institution, not the public or the community. Many journalists acknowledged that public relations often involves spinning information to suit a need or agenda or trying to shape stories to have a predetermined outcome – perhaps a healthy skepticism.

Some rural journalists defined public relations using and the word spin interchangeably. Rural Journalist 18 described the “spin” by city officials when they explain property valuations, saying, “Journalism is getting at the heart of that and knowing when to say, ‘Wait a minute. They’re

saying it that way because they want people to think of it that way.” Rural Journalist 14 said, “The difference is not spinning anything, not giving it a narrative with a goal. ... Some simply want us to print their spin of their message.”

Conversely, Rural Journalist 15 delineated the difference by noting they did not put spin on stories when describing how they approach journalism saying, “I don’t try to put a good spin on it. If it’s an article that needs to be told, it’s not whitewashed or varnished, and to me that’s what public relations would be doing is complete a good foot forward. ... Public relations is basically what a company would do to reach out to the public and to portray themselves in the way they feel they should be portrayed. And journalism is more telling the facts from the people’s perspective.”

At least three of the rural journalists interviewed cited an oft-repeated quote attributed to George Orwell that generally goes: *Journalism is printing something that someone else does not want printed; everything else is public relations.*

Rural Journalists 2, 6, and 18 cited that quote and elaborated; one had posted the quote on social media. Rural Journalist 18 related to that quote saying this of public relations, said, “... I feel like that’s really true because no matter what you’re writing about, you’re gonna find somebody out there who is like, ‘This is fake. This is not real that I’m mad about this. I didn’t want people to know about this.’ Whatever. But really, when it comes down to it, it’s spin.”

Rural Journalist 16 painted a light versus dark picture when comparing journalism and public relations work, saying, “I would say the biased opinion. That’s really what I would say in that because if you’re in a public relations field, I feel like it’s your job to highlight certain things and bring light to what you specifically want to bring light to versus giving an overall picture of

everything that's involved in a certain topic.” Similarly, Rural Journalist 32 described public relations selling something and making a profit. “In journalism, it's about the truth of the matter and including as much information as you can as smoothly and succinctly as you can.”

While many indicated a clear difference between the profession of journalism and public relations, there was an acknowledgement of a need for PR content and contacts.

Public relations fills in the gaps

In regards to RQ2, “how do journalists in rural communities view the role of public relations content in their organizations,” participants said they generally had positive interactions with public relations professionals, and they were crucial for many aspects of newswork. Rural Journalist 17 said public relations professionals and the content they provide are necessary and welcome saying, “It enhances it and puts us closer to the community. Any good will you extend comes back to help you later.” Often, they relied on PR practitioners and public information officers for factual information and were dependent on them for confirming official information – difficult at times because health departments tended to be slow in response.

In practice, how journalists work with PR professionals or sources often helps them to generate a lot more content and publish more local stories and information. PR professionals are often communicating about upcoming events, meetings, and initiatives which are edited for publication. Several journalists mentioned their work included “editing press releases” or social media posts for publication or filling a news hole when they did not have enough reporters to cover the news. With COVID-19, it became more difficult to go places and see people, so digital

communication meant a lot of emails and social media posts. None of the journalists mentioned concerns that PR practitioners or sources were going directly to the public – as if implying this was a fact of doing journalism in a social-mediated world.

Rural Journalist 15 said they “often” use press releases to fill space or because they are of interest to the public, adding, “We did write stories based on press releases that we just gathered additional (information) like you wouldn’t have known about ... before you got the press release.” This journalist also said they sometimes felt pressure from community organizations to run press releases, and it was at that point that they drew a firm line, saying, “Basically in those situations, I would say, ‘Well, we’ll get it in if we have space, and if we don’t have space, you are welcome to pay (as an) advertiser.’”

When considering how PR is helping them to fill the news hole, many journalists discussed a desire to use PR content, but also a frustration with having to depend on it:

The question is bandwidth. It’s hard to do that when you have a news team of four...and to make sure that you cover the city council meeting, or, you know, kind of your prescribed public relations pieces but then also have the time to do the deep investigative or you know those personal stories and those features that take a while to sniff out. (Rural Journalist 29)

A few discussed how their work and definition of journalism directly included editing press releases (Rural Journalist 6, 13). Rural Journalist 6 mentioned their work included “the press release stuff for me that ... you have it through the extension service.” Extension services are often related to agribusiness and farming in rural communities and provide classes, services, and

consulting for free or at a reduced cost. They are usually staffed by university employees and local residents.

In addition others expressed skepticism of fact checking them when there is not an alternative source (Rural Journalist 3). Journalists looked at this use of PR and journalistic content as an editorial responsibility to choose what was fit to write about or include in their newspaper or news stories. That said, there is an acknowledgement of how precarious this process is, and how sometimes they did not know what was in line with their professional training or understanding of what journalism was.

A balancing act

In regard to RQ3, “what lines do rural journalists draw between public relations work and newswork,” rural journalists noted that because of circumstances in rural communities they often find themselves rewriting press releases, covering new business openings, writing positive sports stories, volunteering in the community – performing a community booster type role. For example, Rural Journalist 16 recalled a conversation with a previous sports editor who cautioned them against running negative high school sports stories, saying, “He told me ...regardless if they win or lose to always make the article positive somehow. They are children that are playing the sport and to always find a positive aspect and run with that.” They also discussed an internal debate regarding their desire to paint a losing team or poor performance in that realistic light, but also wanting to be a booster for the community and satisfy readers. Rural journalists were not covering harder hitting news topics, but rather what they thought was of the greatest benefit to the community in relation to social, democratic and informational interests.

In addition, sometimes the content rural journalists have to work with doesn't even classify entirely as *public relations*. As Rural Journalist 17 put it, "In rural communities, you don't get press releases so much as, 'Hey, we took this picture at the rotary meeting. Can you get it in the paper?'" This was one way that rural journalists described their closeness to the community and reliance on community connections. In rural communities, journalists also described a uniquely rural practice: Going straight to the source because there isn't always a media relations team to take their questions. Rural Journalist 19 liked dealing directly with stakeholders better than going through a PR department, "A lot of rural areas don't have PIOs (public information officers), which is kind of nice in some ways. Instead of going through a PIO who might not know anything, I just call the sheriff or the police chief, which is actually kind of nice. I kind of prefer that."

Rural journalists often described the struggle between the pull to maintain the long held norms of journalism and resist the pull of advertising and prevent it from influencing news production while also being a productive member of their communities (Rural Journalists 2, 13). Some journalists specifically said they had been asked to write stories for advertisers or felt pressure to run press releases from certain businesses or advertisers:

I think that rural journalism does come with some advocacy that I wish that I didn't experience ... There's a real desire to see your community thrive and at the very least not get smaller ... I do more stories on the perspective of, 'This is what is good about our community, and this is why it's good.' I do a lot more stories about why (this town) is a good place to live. (Rural Journalist 13)

For example, this same journalist said they don't want to see their small community shrink in size or lose its schools to consolidation, which can mean longer bus rides for kids (Rural Journalist 13). Rural Journalist 3 described the internal conflict they experienced when a community leader or business owner is supplying conflicting information, saying, "There are times I can feel like there's something going on, but they're like putting a happy face on it. I've joked with the publisher that at some point, I'm going to run into somebody that's saying, 'Oh, yes, everything's great here. The business is running fine,' while the business is burning down in the background."

In this way, journalists sometimes play a public relations role, as one journalist put it "We do provide a lot of things for the community. Our PR role is helping to improve our community" (Rural Journalist 12).

Discussion

In a rural community such as Edina, Missouri, the tasks of journalism and public relations can look quite similar – lots of writing, engagement with the community, and a heavy emphasis on events. But as the groundbreaking reporting by the *Edina Sentinel's* Echo Menges reflects, there are stories that depend on the exhaustive persistence of rural journalism, stories that would not otherwise be able to effect change in a community. When Menges broke a story about a group of fifth-and-sixth grade football players who were sexually assaulted by a group of older players in a shared locker room, she placed the emphasis back on the bravery of her own sources in their willingness to tell her what happened. "It took a lot of courage for these kids to tell what happened

inside that locker room. They should be treated like what they are – heroes...They are the ones that put a stop to it” (Menges, 2018).

Throughout journalism studies, substantial literature exists on the overlaps and collaboration between journalism and public relations but little of that focuses on rural communities such as Edina, Missouri, that would have most at stake in the institutions of their 1,000-person town working together. This study aimed to explore the boundary work conducted by rural journalists to differentiate themselves from public relations.

In regards to RQ1, journalists in rural communities described often using public relations content, but they nevertheless were concerned about an overreliance on it. In regards to RQ2, rural journalists primarily relied on standard hard news rationale – that journalism only reflected those topics that public relations would not want reported (Lehman-Wilzig & Seletzky, 2010; Peters, 2011). By analyzing what journalists said about their definitions of PR and journalism, they may see a boundary that in practice is not as clearly defined as is ideal – but is necessary for them to do their work. Journalists in this study did not focus on empathy or justice reporting as part of their image but rather in ways that illuminated issues in the community. They did not clearly acknowledge how public relations had assisted their work but acknowledged that much of their reporting was based on public relations content; they did, however, see their role as one that represented news and journalism to their communities (Burd, 1977).

In regards to RQ 3, what might be rigid lines between the practice of rural journalists and public relations work are more like blended lines in these smaller close-knit communities.

Journalists consistently emphasized a hard boundary between PR and journalism but were often

practicing a soft boundary. While they used PR content and often chose to run stories with more positive “spin,” they were at the same time trying to emphasize their professional differences. They felt it was their duty to interact, engage, and illuminate things in the community in a positive way, and sometimes this meant running or rewriting a press release. This supports previous literature on the presence of boosterism in local news reporting including sports journalism (Anderson, 2000; Kim & Lowrey, 2018).

Taken together the findings reveal how rural community journalists navigate the boundary space between journalism and public relations amid disappearing resources and declining reporting capacity in their newsrooms. In many ways, rural journalists are the first line of defense for their communities against the creeping spread of local news poverty, or “the extent to which local news media are meeting the information needs of people living in rural areas, suburban municipalities and smaller cities and towns” (Lindgren et al., 2016) outside of major metropolitan regions. Lindgren et al. (2016) argue that local news poverty is greatest in communities where residents do not have access to “timely, verified news about local politics, education, health, economic and other key topics they need to navigate daily life.” As a concept, local news poverty extends the oft-referenced concept of news deserts (Abernathy, 2018) to encapsulate a broader definition of local news media (one that is not solely limited to newspapers), specifically focuses on rural and suburban communities, and allows for application outside of an American context.

As the first line of defense against the disappearance of local news, rural journalists take their role as watchdogs seriously. In regards to the first research question, participants invoked well-trodden journalistic norms and ethical standards including objectivity, fairness, and

accountability as the driving forces behind their work – and as key differentiators to distinguish themselves from public relations.

By contrast, participants repeatedly invoked the concept of “spin” in regards to the third research question about the distinction between PR work and newswork. In doing so, participants were referring to public relations practitioners’ responsibility to strategically define the narrative, including by presenting selective – as opposed to balanced and fact-based – information that positions a particular client, group, or community in a positive light. Here, rural journalists engage in boundary work (Carlson & Lewis, 2019), or the practice of distinguishing one category from another to establish the bounds between their professional capacities and those of a closely related – but nonetheless distinct – field. They are strategic in the decisions they make about sources, editing, and how they allot their time.

However, in practice, our interview data reveals that for rural journalists the boundaries between journalism and public relations are decidedly more fluid. In response to the second research question, participants acknowledged that given the increasing threat of local news poverty as a result of resource-strapped newsrooms they find themselves engaging with work that could feasibly be understood as public relations. In other words, in the face of reduced financial, physical, and mental resources, rural journalists have become resourceful about using public relations material strategically in their work. Multiple participants mentioned republishing press releases in their publications – sometimes edited by newsroom staff – to fill space or because it was deemed to be of interest to readers. Thus, while most rural journalists drew on journalistic norms (Belair-Gagnon & Holton, 2018; Carlson, 2015) to emphasize the firm boundaries between their

professional role and that of public relations practitioners, their actual self-described practices revealed a boundary that is substantially more malleable.

One key area where this boundary negotiation emerged in our data was in discussions about sourcing. All journalists depend on their sources including public relations and media professionals for information about happenings in their communities or on their beats. As Rural Journalist 15 mentioned, sometimes the first they hear of a noteworthy community event is through a press release. Importantly, these sourcing relationships, whether with media professionals or directly with community members, serve an agenda-setting function (Cutlip, 2013) and inevitably shape the local journalism that is produced as a result (Sallot & Johnson, 2006; Weder et al., 2023). Journalists conceive their role as one that defines a field of practice and has boundaries and societal power structures which Pierre Bourdieu calls this *habitus* (Costa & Murphy, 2015). For rural journalists, though, gathering new sources is difficult in small communities where the sourcing pool is limited. As several participants noted, they may only have access to a single source for information on certain topic areas. Thus, rural journalists are highly dependent on a small number of sources for their reporting.

Additionally, our data confirm that rural journalists must negotiate a dual role in their communities: a professional role as a journalist but also a social role as a citizen, neighbor, and community member (Mathews, 2021; Perreault, 2021; Robinson, 2023). While this dual perspective affords rural journalists a deep understanding of their communities (Scheufele et al., 2002), it also complicates their editorial decision making when it comes to covering more critical, or less flattering, local stories. Several participants discussed feeling pressure, either implicit or explicit,

to write news stories that present the community in a positive light – anything from a high school sports victory to a heartwarming community fundraiser – that could place their work directly in the “spin” category they deemed to be within the domain of public relations.

These predominantly positive stories could also be understood as a form of journalistic boosterism (Gutsche, 2015). Multiple participants discussed feeling pressure in their professional role to help improve or maintain the community, including by presenting the region as a great place to live, suggesting that local newspapers could be used as a recruitment strategy for potential new residents. Participants also noted that this pressure was sometimes motivated out of fear that their personal interests and quality of life might be affected by fewer residents in their rural locale. In this way, rural journalists blur the boundary between reportage and public relations by acting as journalists and boosters within and for their communities.

Despite boundaries being fuzzy in practice, rural journalists were generally firm in emphasizing the distinctions between journalism and public relations. This response could be understood as a mechanism for ensuring their own relevance – and thus, continued existence – as a community institution amidst a changing local news and information ecosystem. Particularly, in a moment in which local newspapers are rapidly disappearing from rural regions across the country (Abernathy, 2022), accentuating the relatively small differences between journalism and public relations could be seen as a survival strategy. That said, the boundaries of journalism and public relations are less clear given dwindling resources for journalists and the increasing number of PR practitioners. There is an increased dependency on PR practitioners to cover their communities. This harkens to Barnoy’s (2022) concern that journalists relied on PR even when it did not follow

the rules of journalism – it lacked source diversity, multiple perspectives, and accurate information. Yet, there is an increasing symbiosis between journalism and public relations that creates even more dependency and intermingling (Bentele, 2002; Weder et al., 2023) even in rural close-knit communities.

Additionally, while the precarity of the journalism industry is essential for understanding the experiences of rural journalists today, the possibility remains that the boundaries between public relations and journalism in rural communities were always somewhat malleable, and indeed, this study does seem to support the idea of journalism having a soft boundary (Benson, 1999, 2004). Further, findings from this study could offer insights into how local journalists in more densely populated communities – including suburban and urban regions – might negotiate these boundaries as more newsrooms become increasingly resource strapped.

Conclusion

As participants in this study described, rural journalists often conduct *acts of* public relations work for their news organizations by choosing to promote local businesses, choosing a more positive narrative about a community member or sports team, or writing a feel good story about a local non-profit or church because they know people will read it or buy a paper (Duffy et al., 2015; Perreault, 2021; Weder et al., 2023). This management function was strategic for these journalists in that they often chose to cover certain stories because they knew it would positively impact the reputation of their news organization in the local community (Duffy et al., 2015).

All studies have limitations, and this study has three. First, the recruiting procedure was done intentionally through a purposeful sampling procedure – given that there are a variety of

definitions of rural, we wanted to make sure that the journalists who self-identified as rural had also reported in those areas – however, this also means that the sampling is to some degree tied to the research team’s outreach efforts. Second, this study is necessarily limited to the interviewees being journalists. Future research should explore what PR practitioners understand about working in rural communities and how they understand these boundaries given their understanding of PR’s relationship with rural journalism and journalists. Third, journalists’ responses came from experiences that we could not verify through an interview methodology; hence, it may be that they received press releases, for example, that were not actually from public relations professionals and described those interactions in light of PR. Given that much of the description of rural journalism’s overlap with public relations seems oriented towards affecting prosocial change in their community, future research might also consider the activities of rural journalism in relation to solutions journalism.

This study allows for a better understanding of what PR content is more likely to be printed in newspapers and maybe how PR practitioners might find certain successes with content that is pre-written in the journalistic style, clear, concise and adhering to Associated Press style. Journalists will use PR content, especially journalists who find themselves with less time to write original stories. Perhaps the three key takeaways here are: 1) rural journalists acknowledge the need for public relations content that is high quality, trustworthy, and leaves less room for skepticism, and 2) because of digital communication, the public relations content will not be going away anytime soon, and 3) rural journalists espouse traditional news values and norms, yet in practice sometimes take on a community public relations role.

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Appendix

Table A

Participant Number	Region/Title	Gender	Age	Ethnicity
1	Midwest/Reporter	Female	60	White
2	Midwest/Editor	Male	49	White
3	Midwest/Reporter	Male	27	White
4	Midwest/Editor	Female	41	White
5	Midwest/Editor	Female	69	White
6	Midwest/Editor	Male	51	White
7	Midwest/Editor	Male	38	White
8	Midwest/Editor	Male	57	White
9	Midwest/Editor	Male	35	White
10	Midwest/Editor	Female	70	White
11	Midwest/Editor	Male	60	White
12	South/Reporter	Male	66	White
13	Midwest/Reporter	Female	39	White
14	South/Reporter	Male	23	Hispanic
15	Midwest/Reporter	Female	26	White
16	South/Editor	Female	35	Asian-American
17	South/Reporter	Male	57	White
18	South/Editor	Male	24	White
19	South/Reporter	Female	34	White

20	South/Reporter			
21	South/Reporter			
22	South/Reporter	Female	25	White
23	South/Reporter	Female	24	White
24	South/Reporter	Male	55	White
25	South/Editor	Female	26	White
26	South/Reporter	Male	24	White
27	South/Reporter	Female	24	White
28	South/Reporter	Male	56	White
29	Midwest/Reporter	Female	33	White
30	South/Reporter	Female	73	White
31	South/Reporter	Male	24	White
32	South/Reporter	Male	24	White
33	South/Reporter	Female	23	White

Two journalists requested to not share demographics, and given that gender, ethnicity, age is not the primary focus of this study, their interviews were nevertheless included.